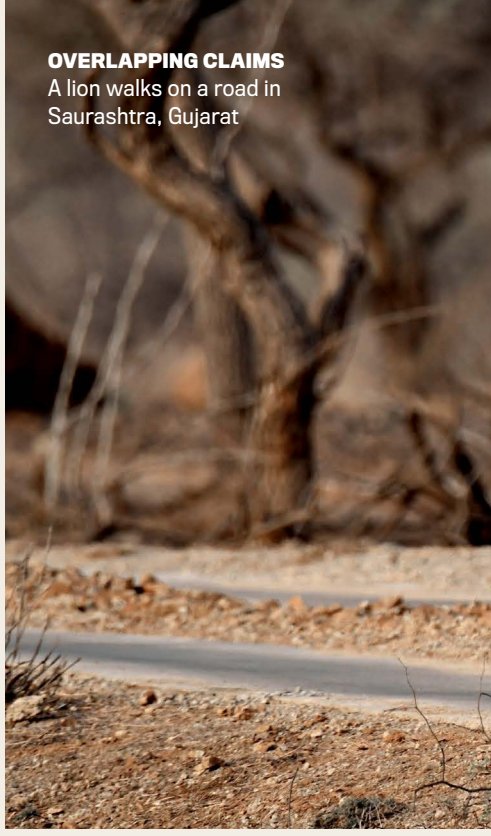
leadership in the past two decades, but also how the SP had failed to develop a Muslim leadership in UP. The signs are clear. Based on its anticipated revival in states it had otherwise been wiped out from, the Congress is building up an appetite. And that means being in competition with similarly-oriented parties.

Having read the *chai* leaves, the SP has decided to hit back. Sources say it will prepare for contesting all 80 Lok Sabha seats in UP. In a recent meeting with state committee office-bearers, Akhilesh asked leaders to be ready for an eventuality where the SP has to contest polls on its own. However, he also added: "...at least 65 seats we will contest; rest may be given to other small parties."

All this puts a big question mark on the INDIA bloc in UP. The continuing frictions with the SP has goaded the Congress to look for other parties to ally with in case seat-sharing arrangements with Akhilesh do not work out. Congress leaders hint that the party is keeping an Option B open—a possible alliance with the Bahujan Samaj Party and/ or the Rashtriya Lok Dal. "Our target is to make our party strong in all 80 seats. We are a part of the INDIA alliance...but we will compromise only to a certain level. We follow *gathbandhan dharm* (coalition norms) but the SP should also follow it," says Congress UP organisation secretary Anil Yadav.

The open war of words in mid-October over seat-sharing in MP had barely died down after a hastily arranged ceasefire—Akhilesh claimed top Congress leaders had made overtures—when there was a skirmish over Rai's attempt to meet senior SP leader Azam Khan in Sitapur jail on October 27. Part of the Congress's Muslim outreach in UP, Rai's comment that the "humanitarian gesture" was meant to fill a gap left by the SP was met with a sharp retort by Akhilesh. SP and Congress leaders feel the gulf between the two parties has widened so much that it cannot be breached without a concerted effort by the two high commands. Such peace talks, they believe, are only possible after the results of the five assembly polls. ■



**OVERLAPPING CLAIMS**
A lion walks on a road in Saurashtra, Gujarat

## LIONS' GATE

- **Gujarat will set up a 475 hectare wildlife safari park in Una, 50 km from the Gir Wildlife Sanctuary**
- **Amid rising man-animal conflict and industrialisation, the move is criticised for fencing in a free-ranging population**
- **State government says it's preserving lion corridors, creating gene pools**

**By Jumana Shah**

Wildlife tourism in Gujarat is getting a boost with the announcement of one more wildlife safari park in the coastal village of Naliya-Mandvi in Una taluka of Gir Somnath district, about 50 km southeast of the Gir Wildlife Sanctuary. Una is close to the Union territory of Diu, a popular tourist area. A few prides of lions—out of a total population of over 674—have made the forested and semi-forested areas of Una their home. The latest decision of the state government to attract more tourists to the region is in line with its vision of helping villagers in the area derive some economic benefit from a burgeoning population of lions. All this comes in the unsalutary backdrop of rising man-animal conflict, as increase in human population, industrialisation and urbanisation in the Saurashtra peninsula have outpaced the increase in lion numbers.

The wildlife park in Una will be spread over approximately 475 hectares. This is the third safari park in the region—the first two being the Sasan Gir Park and the Ambardi Wildlife Park in Amreli. The most popular one, Sasan Park, permits 180-190 tourist taxis within its boundary a day, while the new park in Una will allow 50-60 taxis. "This will reduce the load on Sasan. The Central Zoo Authority's approval is awaited, following which the park could be ready for tourists by 2026," says Gujarat's chief wildlife warden, Nityanand Srivastava.

Over recent decades, south Saurashtra has been undergoing port-led industrial development—territory that lions spilling out of reserve forest areas of Gir are simultaneously reclaiming. Between Bhavnagar and Porbandar, there are seven ports, of which Pipavav and Jafrabad in Amreli district are the biggest, while smaller ports and harbours are all poised for expansion. A fast-spreading rail and road network also poses challenges. In the past one year, 106 lions were found in 36 different instances on railway lines between Amreli and Pipavav. They were driven away by field staff, yet over a dozen lions have been killed in train accidents on this route during the past eight years. In July 2023, three lions were killed. A recent proposal to upgrade metre gauge railway lines to broad gauge and their electrification from the Junagadh to